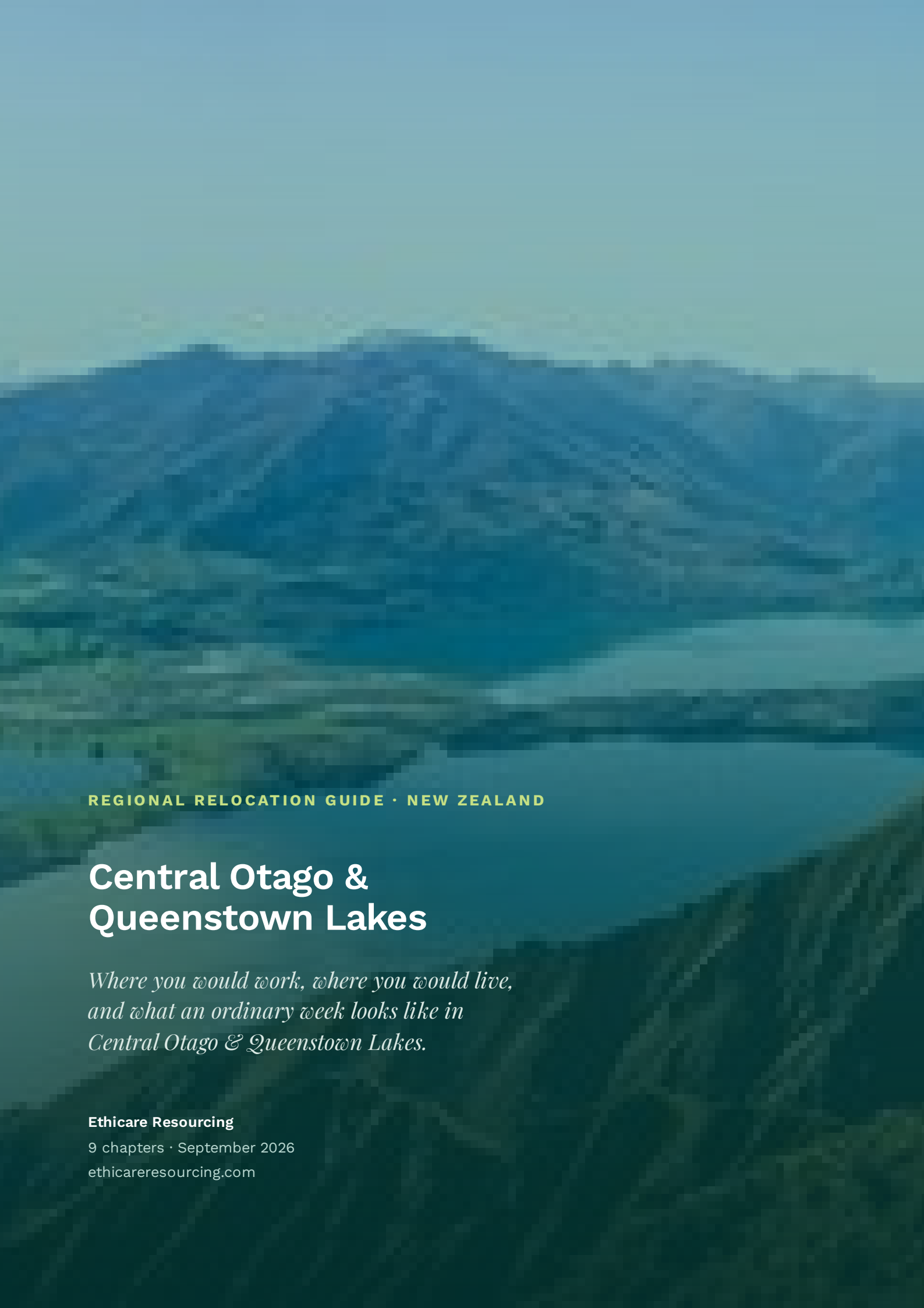




REGIONAL RELOCATION GUIDE · NEW ZEALAND

Central Otago & Queenstown Lakes

*Where you would work, where you would live,
and what an ordinary week looks like in
Central Otago & Queenstown Lakes.*

Ethicare Resourcing

9 chapters · September 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Central Otago

Central Otago Guide · Chapter 1 of 9



Nau mai, haere mai. Central Otago and the Southern Lakes are New Zealand's mountain interior — deep glacial lakes, schist and thyme-covered hills, four true seasons, and the most spectacular landscape in the country. It is also the hardest place in this collection to move to, and we are going to be direct about why.

The most beautiful, most difficult option

This guide covers two adjoining districts that function as one region: **Queenstown Lakes** — Queenstown, Wānaka, Arrowtown, Hāwea — and **Central Otago** proper, the drier inland basins around Cromwell, Alexandra, Clyde and the Maniototo. Together they hold around sixty-five thousand people in an area the size of a small country, ringed by mountains.

Two facts define life here for a clinician. The first is that there is no base hospital. Care is delivered through small rural hospitals and a strong community and primary network, and anything complex travels — three hours by road to Dunedin, or by air. This is rural and remote medicine, and it is a genuinely different job.

The second is the housing market. Queenstown and Wānaka are the least affordable places to live in New Zealand relative to local incomes — worse than Auckland — and rentals are scarce and seasonal. Clinicians make this region work, but they do it deliberately, often by living further inland.

What you get in return is not in dispute. Four ski fields inside an hour. Lakes you swim in. Autumn that stops people in the street. Direct flights to Australia from a town of twenty-eight thousand. And a kind of clinical work — broad, autonomous, mountain-and-adventure-flavoured — that exists almost nowhere else.

Who wrote this

We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.

This is the region we talk the most people out of. Not because it isn't wonderful, but because a holiday here and a life here are different things. Where we think it's the wrong answer, we say so.

The region, in nine numbers

~65,000

Permanent residents across both districts — and several times that in the peak of a good season.

~28,000

In Queenstown, the largest town. Wānaka is around ten thousand, Cromwell and Alexandra smaller again.

0 base hospitals

Rural hospitals and a strong community network, with complex and tertiary work referred out of the region entirely.

~3 hrs

By road to Dunedin, where the region's tertiary care sits. Invercargill is closer; Christchurch is six hours or a short flight.

4 ski fields

Within about an hour of Queenstown. Not a figure of speech — people ski before a late shift.

Least affordable

Housing in New Zealand relative to local income, in Queenstown and Wānaka. This is the single biggest practical obstacle.

~350–450mm

Annual rainfall in the Alexandra basin — semi-arid, the driest place in the country. Queenstown gets roughly double.

–10 to 35°C

The genuine annual range inland. New Zealand's hottest and coldest temperatures are both recorded around here.

Direct to Australia

Trans-Tasman flights from Queenstown Airport. Extraordinary for a town this size, and a real quality-of-life factor.

Six things you only learn once you're here

Living here is not holidaying here

The lake is still beautiful in your third winter. But you'll be doing the school run in it, queueing behind rental cars, and paying resort-town prices for groceries. Almost everyone who leaves, leaves because of this gap.

Finding a rental is the real barrier

Not the money — the supply. Stock is limited, much of it goes to short-stay or seasonal workers, and good properties move in hours. Start early and expect to compromise. [Cost of living](#) is blunt about this.

The seasons run the town

Two peaks — ski winter and summer — with genuine shoulder-season quiet between.

Restaurants close, the roads empty, and locals exhale. It is a rhythm you come to plan your year around.

Winter driving is a skill

Ice, snow, chains, and the Crown Range — the highest sealed road in the country — between Queenstown and Wānaka. Nobody tells you this before you arrive, and everyone learns it fast.

The clinical load is unusual

A small service dealing with a very large volume of adventure and ski injury, in visitors as well as residents. Orthopaedics, trauma and retrieval feature far more than the population would suggest.

Inland is a different region

Cromwell, Alexandra and Clyde are forty-five minutes from Queenstown and belong to another world — drier, hotter, colder, cheaper, quieter and more agricultural. For many clinicians they are the answer.

A note on names

This is the rohe of Kāi Tahu. Lake Wakatipu is Whakatipu-wai-māori, and the trails through these mountains were pounamu routes long before the gold. The 1860s rush is the layer most visible today — the stone cottages of Arrowtown, Clyde and Naseby, and the Chinese miners' settlement at Arrowtown.

You're not expected to arrive fluent in te reo. You are expected to try. [Te ao Māori at work](#) covers pronunciation and the words you'll hear on the ward.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Central Otago and the Southern Lakes specifically. Anything true of New Zealand generally — visas, registration, tax, renting law, driving licences, schools — lives once in [Moving to New Zealand](#) rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read [Healthcare here](#), because the absence of a base hospital changes everything about the job, and [Cost of living](#), because it is the reason most people who want this region cannot have it.

Why Central Otago

Central Otago Guide · Chapter 2 of 9

Almost everyone asks about this region. Very few end up here, and the reasons are practical rather than mysterious. If you understand them going in, Central Otago can be the best decision you ever make.

The arithmetic

Clinical pay in New Zealand is set nationally. You will earn the same in Queenstown as in Invercargill or Palmerston North. What changes is what it costs to live, and here it costs the most in the country.

That is the whole difficulty. A region with resort-town housing costs, national public-sector pay, and no base hospital to build a long career in. Put plainly: you are paying a significant premium, in money and in clinical scope, to live somewhere extraordinary.

People do make it work, and the ones who do tend to have done one of three things. They live inland — Cromwell, Alexandra, Clyde — where housing is a fraction of the price. They arrive as a two-income household. Or they come for a defined chapter of three to five years, knowing exactly what they are buying.

A typical week

Monday to Friday

Ten to twenty minutes to work in Queenstown or Wānaka, though the Frankton corridor grinds at peak. Forty-five minutes if you commute in from Cromwell.

After work, winter

Night skiing or a lit trail, then the pub. In summer, a swim in the lake and light until nearly ten.

Saturday, winter

A ski field. Four of them within about an hour, and a season pass costs less than you'd think when you live here.

Saturday, summer

The lake, a Great Ride, a river, or the Otago Central Rail Trail. Twenty minutes from the door.

Sunday

Mt Aspiring National Park, Roys Peak, the Routeburn, or a vineyard lunch in Bannockburn or Gibbston.

Shoulder season

April–May and October–November. Half the town leaves, prices soften, and the region belongs to residents again. Many locals say it's the best of it.

The six things people ask us

Can I build a career here?

Will I be able to find somewhere to live?

Is it isolated?

Is it a good place with children?

How bad are the winters?

Is the tourism overwhelming?

When we'd steer you to a bigger centre

You want to buy a house

In Queenstown or Wānaka on a clinical salary, this is out of reach for most people. Inland is achievable. Elsewhere in New Zealand it is straightforward.

Your specialty needs a hospital

There is no base hospital here. Most hospital-based specialties simply do not have a role in this region, and that is the plainest fact in this guide.

You need services close by

Complex care for you or your family means Dunedin, Invercargill or Christchurch. For most people that is fine; for some it is decisive.

You don't want to drive in snow

Winter here means ice, chains and mountain passes. It becomes routine, but it is a real change if you have never done it.

You want a settled, local community

The resort towns turn over fast. Friends leave. That transience is invigorating at thirty and wearing at forty-five.

Where we'd steer you instead

Want the South Island, mountains within reach, and a tertiary hospital? **Christchurch** – the Southern Alps are two hours away.

Want a small city with real clinical depth and far cheaper housing? **Dunedin**, three hours south-east, and the tertiary centre this region refers to.

Want lakes, sun and the outdoors with a functioning housing market? **Nelson Tasman**.

Want the far south with a base hospital and housing you can actually buy? **Southland**, two hours south.

In our experience

Central Otago suits clinicians who want the landscape to be the career move — rural-generalist breadth in the country's most spectacular setting. We're direct with everyone about two things: sort housing before you commit, and be sure you're comfortable working further from a tertiary bench.

Central Otago at a glance

Central Otago Guide · Chapter 3 of 9



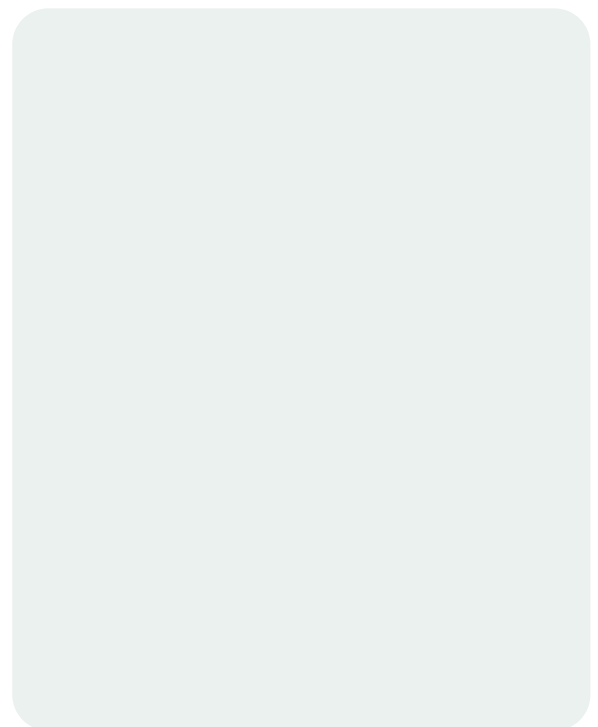
Everywhere else in New Zealand has a maritime climate: mild, damp, moderated by the sea. Central Otago does not. Ringed by mountains that strip the weather of its rain, it is the one genuinely continental corner of the country – and it feels like a different nation.

The shape of the region

Think of it as two halves. The **lakes** sit in the west, where glaciers gouged deep troughs into the Southern Alps: Wakatipu with Queenstown on its edge, Wānaka and Hāwea to the north, the Remarkables and Mt Aspiring National Park behind. It is steep, dramatic country, wetter and greener.

East of the Kawarau Gorge, the land opens into the **basins** – Cromwell, Alexandra, Clyde, and the Maniototo beyond. Rounded schist hills, thyme and wild rose, orchards and vineyards on the valley floors, and the Clutha River running through. This is the dry interior: brown in summer, gold in autumn, frozen and often fog-bound in winter.

Practically: Queenstown to Wānaka is an hour over the Crown Range or ninety minutes the long way. Queenstown to Cromwell is forty-five minutes. Dunedin is three hours, Invercargill a little over two, Christchurch six.



Where Queenstown sits, with the straight-line distance to Wānaka and Cromwell



Lakes to the west, dry basins to the east — two regions in one

The four seasons

Summer

Dec – Feb

24–32°C

Hot, dry, brilliant

Autumn

Mar – May

14–22°C

The famous one

Winter

Jun – Aug

–2 to 10°C

Frost, snow, fog

Spring

Sep – Nov

12–20°C

Blossom, then wind

Indicative. Inland around Alexandra and Clyde the extremes are sharper at both ends than in the lakes.

What the numbers don't tell you

It is the driest place in New Zealand. The Alexandra basin gets somewhere around 350 to 450 millimetres of rain a year — semi-arid, less than parts of Spain. Irrigation is what makes the orchards and vineyards possible. If you have spent years under grey drizzle, the sheer quantity of clear sky here is the thing that changes your mood.

The autumn is genuinely worth planning your year around. Poplars and willows through the gorges and around the lakes turn every shade from lemon to rust, against brown hills and blue water. People travel across the world for it. You will get it from your kitchen window.

Winter is cold, clear and occasionally strange. Hard frosts, real snow, and temperature inversions that trap freezing fog in the inland basins for days at a time while the tops above sit in sunshine. Locals drive up out of it. It is beautiful and it is a genuine adjustment.

The houses are better than the national average. Because they have to be. Insulation, double glazing and log burners are normal here in a way they are not in the warmer north. Still check the Healthy Homes compliance statement, which is a legal requirement and covered in the national [Renting in New Zealand](#) chapter.

Summer is hot and the UV is fierce. Thirty degrees and a thin atmosphere at altitude. Sunburn happens in twenty minutes. Everyone here is careful about it and you will become so too.

Where things are, in driving time

Queenstown → Arrowtown

20 minutes, and the prettiest commute in the guide.

Queenstown → Wānaka

1 hr over the Crown Range in good conditions; 1 hr 30 via Cromwell when it snows.

Queenstown → Cromwell

45 minutes through the Kawarau Gorge. The gateway to the dry interior.

Cromwell → Alexandra / Clyde

20–30 minutes down the Clutha valley.

Queenstown → Dunedin

3 hours. Where tertiary care and the medical school are.

Queenstown → Christchurch

6 hours by road, or an hour in the air.

Words you'll hear

CentralLocals' shorthand for the dry inland basins, as distinct from the lakes.

WhakatipuLake Wakatipu – Whakatipu-wai-māori in full.

The CrownThe Crown Range, between Queenstown and Wānaka. The highest sealed road in the country.

FranktonQueenstown's flat, functional end – airport, hospital, supermarkets.

InversionWinter fog trapped in the basins with sunshine above it.

ShoulderThe quiet weeks between the ski and summer seasons. Locals' favourite.

The Rail TrailThe Otago Central Rail Trail, Clyde to Middelmarsh. New Zealand's original Great Ride.

SchistThe local rock – grey, layered, and in every wall, cottage and hillside.

The short version

The one part of New Zealand with a true continental climate – hot dry summers, hard frosts, real snow, and an autumn people travel the world for. Two regions in one: the lakes to the west, the dry basins to the east. Which you choose decides your rent, your commute and your winter – [Where clinicians live](#) is next.

Healthcare in Central Otago

Central Otago Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



This is the chapter that decides whether Central Otago is possible for you, so we will start with the thing most guides bury: there is no base hospital in this region. Everything else follows from that.

The shape of the service

Care here is delivered through a rural model. There is a small hospital at Frankton, on the edge of Queenstown, providing twenty-four-hour emergency care, inpatient beds, maternity and outpatient services for the Wakatipu basin — run by Health New Zealand I Te Whatu Ora. A second rural hospital serves the Cromwell, Clyde and Alexandra valley inland. Around them sits an unusually important primary and community network: general practice, urgent care, district nursing, community allied health, aged residential care and ambulance.

What is not here: intensive care, most surgical specialties, oncology, cardiology, neurology, and the great majority of hospital-based subspecialty work. That is all referred out — principally to Dunedin, three hours by road, with Invercargill closer for some services and Christchurch used for others. Retrieval and transfer are a normal part of the working week rather than an exception.

What makes the caseload unusual

A resident population of sixty-five thousand, and several million visitor nights a year, many of them spent skiing, biking, climbing, jumping off things and driving on unfamiliar roads. The result is a volume and severity of musculoskeletal and trauma presentation far beyond what the population would predict, concentrated hard into the ski season.

For emergency, orthopaedic, radiography, physiotherapy and pre-hospital clinicians that is interesting work. You see more acute knees, shoulders, wrists and heads in a Queenstown winter than you would in a much larger city. You also stabilise and transfer more, and you do it with fewer people around you.

HOW FAR THE REST OF THE SYSTEM IS

Travel time to each part of the system, to scale against each other. In a region without a base hospital this chart is the job description: only the top two rows are inside the region, and everything below them is a transfer out of it.

The Wakatipu hospital

On the edge of Queenstown
— twenty-four-hour
emergency care, inpatient
beds, maternity and
outpatients



On site

The valley rural hospital

Cromwell, Clyde and
Alexandra — the region's
second site



~45 min

Invercargill

Closer than Dunedin for
some services



~2 hr 15

Dunedin

The main referral centre:
intensive care, most
surgical specialties,
oncology, cardiology,
neurology



~3 hours

Indicative driving times in good conditions; several of these roads are alpine and close in winter. Christchurch, further again at roughly six hours, is used for some tertiary services. Retrieval and transfer are a normal part of the working week here rather than an exception — which is precisely what makes the clinical work interesting to the people who choose it.

Which professions this region suits

Strong fit

Rural generalist medicine, general practice, urgent care, emergency nursing, radiography, physiotherapy, community allied health, midwifery, paramedicine and retrieval.

Possible, with planning

Sonography, occupational therapy, mental health and addiction, aged care, and roles that combine a clinical caseload with travel across the region.

Difficult or unavailable

Most hospital subspecialties, intensive care, radiation therapy, oncology, and anything requiring tertiary volume. Those roles are in Dunedin or Christchurch.

Genuine autonomy

Small teams, no subspecialist down the corridor, and decisions that are yours. Clinicians who want that find it exhilarating; clinicians who want backup find it exposing.

Seasonal intensity

The winter peak is real and it is relentless. So is the shoulder-season quiet that follows it. The year has a shape here.

Workforce transience

People come for a few seasons and move on, which keeps teams young and turnover high.

Continuity is the service's standing challenge.

Working with te ao Māori

This is the rohe of Kāi Tahu, whose relationship with these mountains, lakes and pounamu trails long predates the gold. The Māori population share here is lower than in most of the North Island, and the health equity picture inland – rural, dispersed, ageing, with real access barriers – is a significant part of the work.

Practically: karakia at the start of meetings, te reo used on the ward, whānau involved in decisions. You are not expected to arrive fluent – you are expected to try. The national chapter [Te ao Māori at work](#) covers pronunciation, the words you will hear and marae etiquette.

What to ask at interview

Is there accommodation support? Ask this first, and ask it directly. In this region it matters more than anything else on the list.

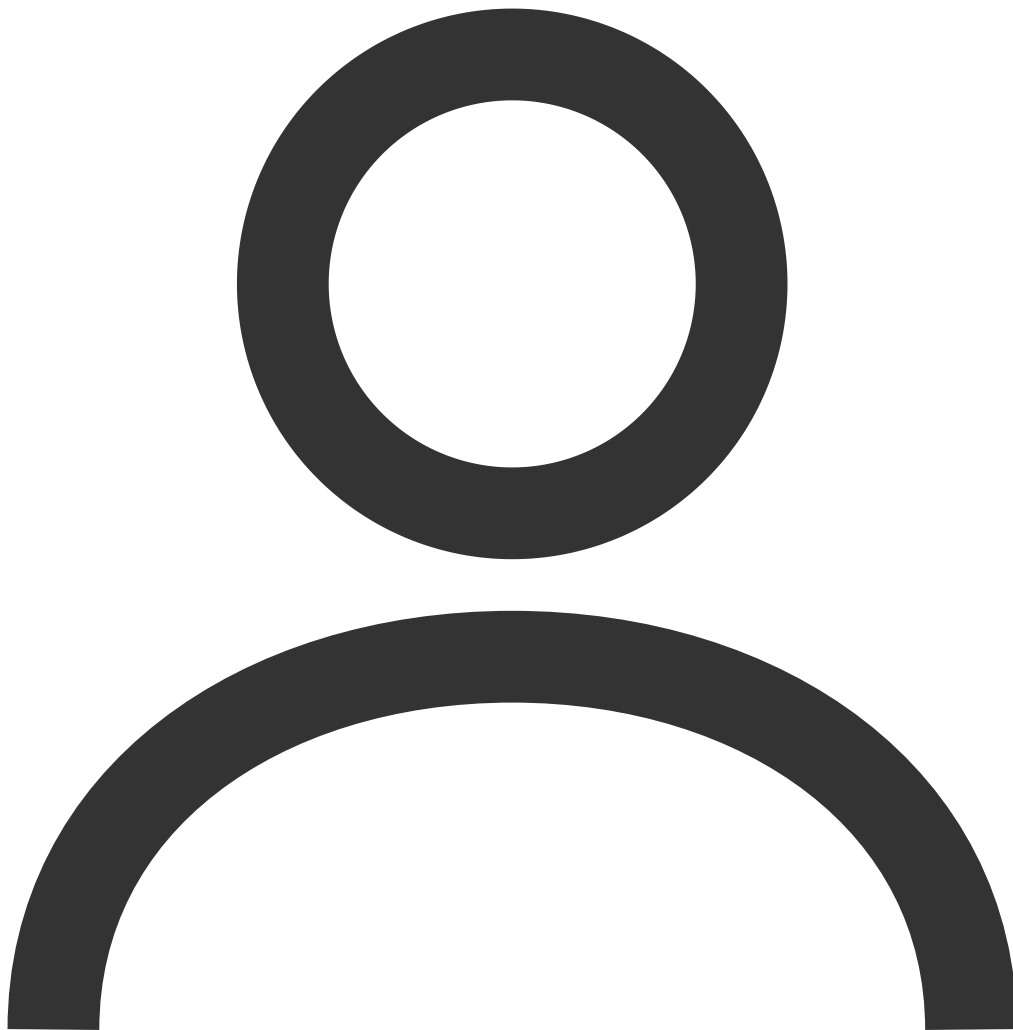
What is referred out, where to, and what is my role in stabilising and transferring?

How does the roster change between the winter peak and the shoulder season?

What senior support is available on site and by phone, particularly overnight?

What professional development and study support exists, given the distance from a tertiary centre?

What does the team's turnover look like, and how long do people typically stay?



Sophie

Sophie's insight

Everyone asks me about Queenstown. My first question back is always about housing, and my second is whether their profession actually has a job here — because without a base hospital, for many people it doesn't. When it does line up, I have never seen anyone regret it.

Sophie Careem Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

Before you can start

Registration with your professional body, and the visa that goes with it, are national processes and identical wherever in New Zealand you land. They are explained once, properly, in [Eligibility & registration](#) and [Immigration & visas](#).

How the health system is funded and structured – ACC (accident cover for everyone, no fault attached), primary care, what things cost, how it differs from the NHS or a private system – lives in [How the health system works](#). ACC matters more here than almost anywhere: it is the reason an injury-heavy region can treat visitors and residents alike without a bill.

Ethicare

[Live roles & professions](#)



What we're recruiting for now, by profession and by region.
[Nearby](#)



The tertiary centre this region refers to, three hours away – and a serious option in its own right.

Where clinicians live

Central Otago Guide · Chapter 5 of 9

In this region the choice of town is the single biggest financial decision you will make. The difference between the lakeside and forty-five minutes inland is not a matter of taste – it is the difference between renting comfortably and struggling.

THREE WAYS TO LIVE IN ONE REGION

The town you pick sets your budget more than any other choice in this guide. These are the three patterns, from the lake outward.

The Wakatipu basin

Closest to the hospital and the mountains, at the region's hardest prices — most clinicians land at the flat, practical Frankton end.

Queenstown

Frankton · the hospital

Arrowtown · 20 min

The Wānaka side

Calmer and more residential, with its own rural hospital — and costs that track Queenstown's more closely than people hope.

Wānaka

Albert Town

Hāwea · 20 min

Inland, where the numbers work

Three-quarters of an hour from the lakes, the same salary buys a very different life — the trade is the daily drive.

Cromwell · 45 min

Clyde

Alexandra

Rental stock is thin everywhere here — start looking before you land, and treat any listed figure as a starting bid rather than a price.

The Wakatipu basin

Queenstown central & Fernhill

Walkable to the lake, the town and the gondola. Beautiful, expensive, and busy for much of the year. Apartments and townhouses more than family homes.

Frankton & Remarkables Park

The flat, practical end of Queenstown — the hospital, the airport, the supermarkets and most of the newer housing. Where a lot of clinicians actually live, and the shortest commute in the basin.

Arrowtown

A gold-era village of stone cottages and autumn poplars, twenty minutes from Frankton. Genuine community, excellent primary school, and prices that reflect all of it.

Lake Hayes & Shotover Country

Newer family subdivisions between Queenstown and Arrowtown. Modern warm houses, sensible commutes, and the best compromise many families find.

Kelvin Heights & Jack's Point

Across the water on the peninsula. Quiet, spectacular and a little removed — a longer drive round the bay, or a ferry.

Glenorchy

Forty-five minutes up the lake, at the head of the Routeburn. Tiny, wild and beloved. Not a practical commute for most, and glorious if it is.

Wānaka and Hāwea

Wānaka

Calmer than Queenstown, more residential, and increasingly its own town rather than an alternative to one. Lake, mountains, good schooling. Costs almost as much and has even less rental stock.

Albert Town & Hāwea

Ten to twenty minutes from Wānaka, more family-oriented and better value. Hāwea in particular is where Wānaka families move when the numbers stop working.

Hillside housing above the basin

Inland — where the numbers work

Cromwell

Forty-five minutes from Queenstown on Lake Dunstan, ringed by orchards and vineyards. Growing fast, genuinely affordable by comparison, with a college and real services. The most common answer for clinical families in this region.

Alexandra

The service town of inland Central, with the valley's rural hospital nearby. Hot summers, cold foggy winters, and housing at a fraction of lakeside prices.

Clyde

A restored gold-era village on the Clutha, at the end of the Rail Trail. Small, characterful and much loved — and priced above Alexandra for the privilege.

The Maniototo & Roxburgh

Ranfurly, Naseby, Roxburgh — small, remote, stone-and-schist farming and orchard country. The cheapest housing in the region by a wide margin, and a real rural life.

Four things to sort before you commit

Accommodation, before anything else. Ask your employer what support exists, start looking months ahead, and be ready to take something imperfect to get a foothold. Supply, not price, is what defeats people here.

Model the inland option properly. Cromwell or Alexandra with a forty-five minute commute may leave you thousands better off a year and in a warmer house. Run the numbers before you rule it out.

Secondary schooling. Choice is limited across the region, and the right college may decide your town. See [Schools & education](#).

Winter access. If you'll commute over the Crown Range, understand what that means in July – and see [Getting around](#).

How renting works – the application pack, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards – is national and covered once in [Renting in New Zealand](#). Worth reading closely before you apply here, because you will be competing.

Cost of living

Central Otago Guide · Chapter 7 of 9



We would rather lose your interest here than have you arrive and discover it. Queenstown and Wānaka are the least affordable places to live in New Zealand relative to local income — harder than Auckland — and the constraint is not only price. It is supply.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the relationship between places — which suburb, ring or region you choose — and the judgement about which costs catch people out. That is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Central Otago against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

Why it is like this

Three decades of international demand for a finite amount of buildable land in a glacial valley, combined with a housing stock in which a large share is holiday homes, short-stay rental or seasonal-worker accommodation. Add a workforce that arrives every winter needing somewhere to live, and long-term rentals become genuinely scarce rather than merely expensive.

Clinical pay, meanwhile, is national. You arrive on the same salary you would earn in Palmerston North, into the country's most expensive market. There is no regional loading that closes that gap.

The practical consequence is that finding somewhere to live is the hardest part of moving here, harder than registration or the visa. Ask any prospective employer what accommodation support exists before you accept anything, start looking months out, and read the inland section below properly.

What it costs, by area

Queenstown & central Wānaka

The top of the national range for both rent and purchase. A family home near the lake is out of reach on a single clinical salary, and competition for good rentals is intense.

Frankton, Lake Hayes, Shotover Country

Still expensive, but this is where the practical stock is – newer, warmer houses and the region’s shortest commutes. Where most clinicians in the basin end up.

Arrowtown & Kelvin Heights

Village and lakeside premiums. Lovely, limited, and priced accordingly.

Albert Town & Hāwea

Meaningfully cheaper than Wānaka itself, ten to twenty minutes out, and more family housing.

Cromwell

A different market entirely, forty-five minutes from Queenstown. Family homes at a fraction of lakeside prices, with real services and a college.

Alexandra, Clyde & the Maniototo

The most affordable housing in the region by a wide margin. Alexandra in particular offers ordinary family living at ordinary New Zealand prices.

THE WAKATIPU PREMIUM, IN ONE NUMBER

The same small place to live, priced by whether it has a Wakatipu address.
This single decision moves more money than every other line in this chapter put together.



Monthly rent for a room or small one-bedroom, expressed against inland Central as the baseline. Over a year the gap is worth more than half a year’s inland rent. Cromwell is the compromise most clinicians in the basin settle on – still expensive, but newer, warmer houses and the region’s shortest commutes.

Indicative prices that change over time. Note the two rent lines – that single row is the most consequential number in this guide.

The costs particular to here

Groceries carry a resort premium

Ten to twenty per cent above a main centre in Queenstown and Wānaka. The supermarkets at Frankton and Cromwell are where locals do the big shop.

Eating out is expensive

You are sharing restaurants with people on holiday. Locals eat out less and cook more, which is a genuine lifestyle adjustment.

Winter power, and a winter car

Real heating costs, plus tyres, chains and servicing. Both are worth spending properly on.

The mountain habit

Season passes, gear, bikes, boats. It is the whole reason you came, and it is a line in the budget rather than an afterthought.

Work out your own numbers

Compare cities



Queenstown prices for rent, groceries, transport and dining, against your current city.

(<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Queenstown-New-Zealand>)

Plan your budget

Sorted budget planner



New Zealand's free, government-backed budgeting tool.

(<https://sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner/>)

Official data



The Household Living-Costs Price Index, updated quarterly.

(<https://www.stats.govt.nz/topics/household-living-costs-price-indexes/>)

Property



Compare Queenstown, Wānaka, Cromwell and Alexandra side by side. Do this early.

(<https://www.realestate.co.nz/residential/sale/otago/central-otago>)

Sanity check



A cleaner side-by-side of two cities. Worth running when Numbeo looks off.

(<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>)

Official rents



Bond-lodgement data by area – the most reliable rent figure in New Zealand.

(<https://www.tenancy.govt.nz/rent-bond-and-bills/market-rent/>)

How pay, tax, IRD numbers, KiwiSaver and sending money home actually work is national and explained once in **Money, tax & banking**.

The honest summary

You can live well here on a clinical salary, but almost certainly not beside the lake, and almost certainly renting. The clinicians who make this region work either live inland, arrive as a two-income household, or come for a defined few years with their eyes open. All three are good answers. Pretending the numbers are otherwise is not.

Getting around

Central Otago Guide · Chapter 6 of 9

Two things surprise people about getting around this region. The first is how much winter driving is involved. The second is that a resort town of twenty-eight thousand people has direct international flights, which changes the calculation about being far from anywhere.

You will need a car

There is no meaningful alternative. The towns are strung along valleys and lakesides, work may be in a different one from home, and the good parts of living here — the ski fields, the trailheads, the lakes — all assume a vehicle. Most households run two, and a four-wheel drive or at least good winter tyres is a common first purchase.

Queenstown itself has a genuine traffic problem for its size, concentrated on the Frankton corridor and the approach into town. It is a valley with limited routes and a very large number of rental cars. Twenty minutes can become forty-five in peak season.

The passes

The Crown Range

Queenstown to Wānaka, and the highest sealed road in New Zealand. Spectacular, and in winter it means ice, snow and sometimes chains. The Cromwell route is the longer, safer alternative and locals switch to it without fuss.

The Kawarau Gorge

Queenstown to Cromwell. The main link between the lakes and inland Central, and generally the most reliable road in the region.

The Lindis Pass

North towards the Mackenzie Country and Christchurch. Beautiful, exposed and occasionally closed in winter.

The Haast Pass

West from Wānaka to the West Coast. A stunning drive, prone to closure after heavy rain or slips.

Winter driving, honestly

You will learn to check road conditions before leaving the house, carry chains in the boot between June and September, and know how to fit them. Everyone here does; nobody arrives knowing how.

Black ice on shaded corners is the real hazard, not deep snow. Slow down, leave earlier, and accept that some mornings the Crown Range is not the route.

If your commute crosses a pass, ask your employer about winter rostering. Some services build it in.

Buses, and their limits

Queenstown has a subsidised local bus network across the Wakatipu basin — Frankton, Arrowtown, Kelvin Heights, Jack's Point — and it is genuinely cheap and well used by hospitality and seasonal workers. There are inter-town coach services to Wānaka, Cromwell and beyond, and a summer ferry across the lake.

What there is not: any rail, any real evening or rural frequency, and any prospect of managing a clinical roster across towns without a vehicle. Treat the bus as a useful supplement, not a plan.

Flying — the region's quiet advantage

Queenstown Airport

At Frankton, minutes from the hospital. Frequent domestic flights to Auckland, Wellington and Christchurch.

Direct to Australia

Trans-Tasman services to the eastern Australian cities. Remarkable for a town this size, and the thing that makes being here feel less remote than the map suggests.

Getting home

One domestic or trans-Tasman hop, then long-haul. For clinicians with family in Australia it is easier than from most of New Zealand.

The catch

It's an alpine airport in a valley. Fog, snow and wind cause diversions and delays, mostly in winter. Build in a buffer for anything that matters.

Distances worth knowing

Journey	Typical time
Queenstown → Frankton	10–20 min
Queenstown → Arrowtown	20 min
Queenstown → Coronet Peak / the Remarkables	25–40 min
Queenstown → Wānaka (Crown Range)	1 hr, weather permitting
Queenstown → Cromwell	45 min
Cromwell → Alexandra / Clyde	20–30 min
Queenstown → Glenorchy	45 min
Queenstown → Invercargill	2 hr 15
Queenstown → Dunedin	3 hr
Queenstown → Christchurch	6 hr, or 1 hr flying

Summer times on dry roads. Add generously for winter, for the Crown Range in any doubt, and for the Frankton corridor in peak season.

Converting your licence, buying a car, and what a warrant of fitness and registration involve are national matters, explained once in [Driving & licences](#).

Food, shopping & the everyday

Central Otago Guide · Chapter 8 of 9



A semi-arid valley with hot days, cold nights and irrigation turns out to be very good at growing two things: stone fruit and pinot noir. Both are as good as anywhere, both are grown within half an hour of each other, and both are cheaper here than anywhere else on earth.

What the region grows

Cherries and apricots from Cromwell and Roxburgh in December and January, sold from roadside stalls and orchard gates at prices that make no sense to anyone who has bought them in a European supermarket. Then peaches, nectarines, plums, berries and apples through to autumn. The Clutha valley is one of the great fruit-growing districts.

And the wine. Central Otago is the southernmost wine region in the world and one of the finest pinot noir districts anywhere — Bannockburn, Gibbston, Bendigo, Pisa, Alexandra. Cellar doors are twenty minutes from most of the region, and Saturday lunch at a vineyard becomes an ordinary thing rather than an occasion.

Markets round it out: the Cromwell and Alexandra farmers' markets for produce, the Queenstown and Wānaka markets for a mix of food and craft. Between the stalls, the orchards and the cellar doors you can eat extremely well from within forty kilometres.

Eating out

Queenstown

A restaurant scene far beyond the town's size, because it is feeding several million visitor nights a year. Excellent at the top end, and priced for people on holiday.

Wānaka

Smaller, more relaxed and increasingly good. Fewer tourists, more locals, better value.

Arrowtown & Clyde

Gold-era villages with a handful of very good places each. Worth the drive, and the kind of thing you show visiting family.

Coffee

Excellent everywhere, as across New Zealand. A flat white in a Cromwell café will beat the best in most British cities.

Groceries and the practical stuff

The large supermarkets are at Frankton, Wānaka, Cromwell and Alexandra, and that is where locals shop. Prices carry a resort premium in the lakes towns – noticeably higher than a main centre – and food in New Zealand is already expensive by British or Australian standards.

Specialist and imported ingredients are the honest weak point. The range here is narrower than in any city in this collection, and if a particular cuisine is central to how your family eats you should check before committing. Queenstown's international workforce means more than you might expect – the national chapter [Finding your feet & your people](#) covers where to look and which communities are established here.

The rhythm of the year

Two peaks, two lulls

Ski winter and high summer are full and fast. April–May and October–November are quiet, cheaper and, most locals will tell you, the best of it.

Your social circle turns over

Seasonal workers arrive and leave. It makes the towns easy to join and hard to settle in. Inland Central is the opposite – slower to break into, and then permanent.

Everything is outdoors

Social life here is a trail, a lake, a mountain or a vineyard. Joining a club – cycling, tramping, ski, netball, rugby – is the fastest route to knowing people properly.

Culture means travelling

There is a real festival and event calendar, but for major touring acts, galleries and theatre you are looking at Dunedin or Christchurch.

Honest limitations

Retail is tourist-facing. Serious shopping means Dunedin, Christchurch or online, and online delivery to inland addresses can be slow.

Specialist groceries are genuinely limited compared with any city.

Eating out regularly at resort prices is how budgets quietly fail here. Almost everyone who stays learns to cook more.

Snow, lakes & the rail trail

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This is the chapter that needs no argument. Four ski fields inside an hour, three glacial lakes, a national park at the end of the road, and the country's original Great Ride. Whatever else this region asks of you, it delivers here completely.

THE NUMBER THAT ORGANISES WINTER

4

SKI FIELDS INSIDE ABOUT AN HOUR

Coronet Peak, the Remarkables, Cardrona and Treble Cone all sit within reach of an ordinary day off – one of them close enough for night skiing after a shift. A season here needs no flights and no accommodation, which changes what skiing costs and, more importantly, what it is: not an annual holiday but a weekly habit.

The detail on each field is below; summer's lakes, rivers and trails follow it.

Winter

Coronet Peak

Twenty-five minutes from Queenstown, with night skiing. The one you go to after a day shift.

The Remarkables

Above Frankton, up a long access road. Wide bowls, good learning terrain, and the view that ends up in everyone's photographs.

Cardrona

On the Crown Range between Queenstown and Wānaka. Family favourite, big terrain park, and a good season.

Treble Cone

Wānaka's field, and the serious one — long steep faces above Lake Wānaka. Advanced skiers plan their winters around it.

Beyond the lifts

Backcountry touring, cross-country at Snow Farm, ice skating and curling at Naseby, and the Pisa and Old Woman ranges for ski touring.

What a season costs

Less than you think once you live here. A pass is a few hundred to fifteen hundred dollars depending on the field, and there is no travel or accommodation to pay for.

Summer — the lakes and the rivers

Wakatipu, Wānaka and Hāwea are deep, cold, clear glacial lakes, and in January they are genuinely swimmable. Add Lake Dunstan at Cromwell, which is warmer and shallower and where inland families spend their summers on the water.

Then the rivers: the Kawarau, the Shotover, the Clutha and the Matukituki. Jet boats, rafting, fishing, and gorges of an unreasonable colour. Rock climbing at Wye Creek and Queenstown Hill, paragliding off the gondola, and lake swimming that stays possible into April.

On foot and on two wheels

The Otago Central Rail Trail

Clyde to Middelmarsh through the Maniototo — New Zealand's first Great Ride, on an old railway formation. Gentle, remote, and one of the great multi-day rides anywhere.

The Queenstown Trail & Lake Dunstan Trail

Purpose-built riding at its best. The Lake Dunstan Trail from Cromwell to Clyde is spectacular enough to be worth moving here for on its own.

Roys Peak & Isthmus Peak

The Wānaka classics — steep, relentless and worth every step. Go early to have them to yourself.

Mt Aspiring National Park

At the end of the road from Wānaka and Glenorchy. Rob Roy Glacier for a day, the Routeburn and Rees-Dart for longer, and serious alpine country beyond.

The Roys Peak track above Lake Wānaka

Mountain biking

The Queenstown Bike Park off the gondola, Coronet in summer, Sticky Forest at Wānaka, and Bannockburn's dry-country trails.

Gold trails and thyme country

Bendigo, Bannockburn sluicings and the old workings around Arrowtown and Naseby – walkable history in an extraordinary landscape.

Four ski fields within about an hour

Further afield

Fiordland – 2 hr

Te Anau, Milford and Doubtful Sound. One of the great wildernesses on earth, and a weekend away.

The Catlins & the Southern Scenic Route – 3 hr

Wild coast, waterfalls, penguins and sea lions.

The Mackenzie Country – 2 hr 30

Aoraki / Mount Cook, Lake Tekapo and the dark-sky reserve.

The West Coast – 3 hr

Over the Haast Pass to rainforest, glaciers and the Tasman.

Dunedin – 3 hr

The nearest city, for galleries, gigs, the peninsula's wildlife and a change of pace.

Australia – direct

Trans-Tasman flights from Queenstown make a long weekend in Melbourne or Sydney genuinely realistic.

Useful links

Tourism

Queenstown NZ



The official visitor site for the Wakatipu basin: trails, fields, events and conditions.

(<https://www.queenstownnz.co.nz/>)

Tourism



Inland Central – the rail trail, the orchards, the wine and the gold towns.

(<https://www.centralotagonz.com/>)

Outdoors



Tracks, huts, alerts and bookings for Mt Aspiring National Park and beyond.

(<https://www.doc.govt.nz/>)

Winter essential



Live road, snow and closure information. You will use this weekly from June to September.

(<https://www.journeys.nzta.govt.nz/>)

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Central Otago and the Southern Lakes. Everything national – visas, registration, tax, renting, driving, schools, te ao Māori – lives in **Moving to New Zealand**. If this is the region for you, the next conversation should be about **where you'd actually live** – and then **talk to us**, with no pressure and no pipeline.